DIGITALAIKART ORIGINAL

The Design Entrance 2027 Playbook

UCEED - CEED - NIFT - NID

Four doors, three deadlines, eleven weeks. One plan.

UCEED	CEED	NIFT	NID
17 Jan 2027	17 Jan 2027	10 Jan 2027	20 Dec 2026

Every official date, fee, marking rule, seat number and refund clause, verified from IIT Bombay, NTA, NIFT and NID on 31 October 2026.

Where the rank is really won. Which deadline closes first. What the weightage actually rewards. What to draw, and when to stop drawing.

2027-28 ADMISSION CYCLE

Prepared 31 October 2026 - digitalkartai.shop

Digital Edition

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Read the first two chapters before you register

This book has one job: to get you registered for the right design entrances, in the right order, before the windows close - and then to make the eleven weeks between now and 17 January 2027 count.

It is written for the 2027-28 admission cycle and it is time-sensitive in a way most guides are not. On the date this was prepared, 31 October 2026, the regular-fee registration for UCEED and CEED closed that same day, with a late window to 6 November. NIFT closes on 16 November. NID closes on 30 November. NID's preliminary test is on 20 December, six weeks before the other two exams. If you are reading this in November, start at Chapter 5 and register first; come back to the rest later.

Three kinds of content sit in these pages, and it is worth knowing which is which.

- Verified fact. Dates, fees, marking schemes, weightages, seat matrices, cut-offs, refund rules. Every one is sourced from a document published by the body that runs the exam, and Chapter 44 lists each source with the version checked.
- Arithmetic. Where the official rules have a consequence that is not obvious - the Part B cut-off that discards a 190-mark Part A score, the weightage that makes the CAT worth more than the GAT and the Situation Test combined - the consequence is computed, not asserted.
- Method. The eleven-week plan, the daily block, the drawing drills, the error log. These are judgement, offered as a workable default rather than a rule.

What this book will not do is promise you a seat. 245 seats exist across seven IITs, 3,423 across twenty NIFT campuses, and nine per discipline at each NID campus. The numbers are in Chapter 3 precisely so that nobody mistakes this for a lottery they are certain to win. What you can control is whether you are registered, prepared and in the right room on the right day.

> **A note on accuracy**
> Conducting bodies correct and revise their own calendars. UCEED states that changes are notified as addendums on the official website only, and NIFT labels parts of its schedule tentative. Every date in this book was correct on 31 October 2026. Confirm it on the official portal before you rely on it, and treat the official portal as the only authority.

CONTENTS

What is in this playbook

DECIDE BEFORE YOU REGISTER 5

01 What each exam actually buys you 5

02 Which door is yours 5

03 The seat arithmetic nobody puts on a poster 6

04 The money map 6

THE DEADLINE MAP 7

05 The master calendar 7

06 UCEED 2027, step by step 8

07 NIFTEE 2027, step by step 9

08 NID DAT 2027, step by step 9

09 CEED 2027, in brief 10

10 Twelve registration errors that end a candidature 10

UCEED, DECODED 11

11 The paper, in full 11

12 The marking maths that decides your Part A 11

13 Part A's six question families 12

14 Part B is a gate, and it is the gate most people fail 13

15 The 60-minute Part B drill 13

NIFT, DECODED 14

16 Where the NIFT rank is actually won 14

17 The GAT: 100 questions in 120 minutes 14

18 The CAT: three questions, three hours 15

19 The Situation Test: seven parameters, one model 15

20 The B.F.Tech fork 16

NID, DECODED 16

21 DAT Prelims: a paper test, on 20 December 2026 16

22 DAT Mains: two tests, one merit list 17

23 Nine seats, and how to choose a discipline 17

CONTENTS, CONTINUED

THE ELEVEN WEEKS 18

24 The week-by-week plan 18

25 The daily ninety minutes 18

26 Drawing: the five things that get marked 19

27 The observation journal 19

28 Mocks, and how to review them 20

AFTER THE EXAM 20

29 UCEED to a B.Des seat: five rounds and three traps 20

30 NIFT after the paper 21

31 NID after the prelims 21

32 If it does not work 21

PRACTICE 22

33 The next 48 hours 22

34 UCEED Part A: twenty practice questions 22

35 Answer key, with the reasoning 23

36 Drawing prompts: what a strong answer contains 24

37 NIFT GAT: fourteen practice questions 25

38 NID: eight studio and sensitivity prompts 26

39 NIFT's seven specialisations and twenty campuses 26

40 Five myths that cost candidates a year 27

THE TOOLKIT 28

41 The master checklist 28

42 Exam-day scripts 28

43 The money worksheet 29

44 Sources and verification log 29

45 Glossary 30

BEYOND THE EXAM 30

46 What the work is actually like 30

47 The parent's page 31

48 If you are reading this after the deadlines 32

PART ONE

Decide before you register

Four entrance exams decide almost every undergraduate and postgraduate design seat in India. Three of them open their application windows within eight weeks of each other, and two close within a fortnight of this book being written. That is the whole problem: most aspirants pick a college they like, then discover the exam that gates it has already closed.

So this book starts backwards. First you work out which door is yours and what it costs to walk through it. Then you register in the right order. Only then do you open a sketchbook.

01 What each exam actually buys you

The four exams are not competitors. They lead to different institutions, different degrees and very different numbers of seats. Getting this straight in the first ten minutes saves you weeks.

Exam	What it gates	Who runs it	2027 exam date
UCEED	B.Des at 7 IITs (IIT Bombay, Delhi, Guwahati, Hyderabad, Indore, Roorkee, IIITDM Jabalpur) plus 47 institutes that accept the score	IIT Bombay	17 Jan 2027
CEED	M.Des and PhD at 11 institutes (8 IITs, IISc Bangalore, IIITDM Jabalpur, IIITDM Kancheepuram) plus score-sharing institutes	IIT Bombay	17 Jan 2027
NIFTEE	B.Des and B.F.Tech at 20 NIFT campuses, plus lateral entry and artisan routes	NTA for NIFT	10 Jan 2027
NID DAT	B.Des and the 5.5-year integrated M.Des at NID Ahmedabad, Gandhinagar, Bengaluru, Andhra Pradesh, Assam, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh	NID	20 Dec 2026

Two things jump out. NID's preliminary test is six weeks before the others, so it sets your preparation clock, not UCEED. And CEED is not an undergraduate exam at all - it is the masters route, which means a Class 12 student should ignore it entirely and a final-year graduate should ignore UCEED.

02 Which door is yours

Answer one question honestly and the rest follows.

- I am in Class 12 now, or passed it in 2026 and am taking a year. Your doors are UCEED, NIFTEE and NID DAT. Sit all three. CEED is closed to you.
- I am in the final year of a three-year degree or already graduated. Your door is CEED for M.Des, and NIFTEE M.Des if you want a management or technology masters. UCEED and NID B.Des are closed to you.
- I did a diploma and want to enter a design degree in the second year. That is NIFT's NLEA route, not the regular entrance.
- I am already inside a design or fashion programme and want to transfer. NIFT's Student Permanent Transfer policy runs before NLEA seats open. Ask your campus academic office, not the entrance exam cell.

If you are in the first group, the next three paragraphs matter more than anything else in this book.

UCEED has an eligibility gate that catches people who assume they can retry freely. You may attempt it a maximum of two times, and those attempts must be in consecutive years. You must also have appeared for Class XII for the first time in 2026 or 2027. Someone who first sat Class XII in 2025 cannot appear in 2027 at all, even with a gap year. There is one narrow exception: if your board declared 2024-25 results on or after 30 September 2025, you are still eligible.

NID's age gate is stricter than most people expect. For Indian nationals in the General and General-EWS categories, you must have been born on or after 1 July 2006. That is a hard cut-off, not a guideline, and it is earlier than UCEED's 1 October 2002 cut-off would suggest for a comparable cohort.

NIFT has the loosest gate: any stream at 10+2, under 24 years of age as on 1 August of the admission year, with five years of age relaxation for SC, ST, PwD and PwBD candidates. If you are a commerce or arts student who assumed design was closed to you, NIFT is where that assumption is wrong.

The stream myth

Every one of these four exams admits Science, Commerce and Arts students. UCEED's brochure says it in capitals: ANY STREAM. NID's handbook says 'in any stream (Science, Arts, Commerce, Humanities etc.)'. The only place stream matters is NIFT's B.F.Tech programme, which requires Mathematics at 10+2 - and even then, a B.F.Tech candidate who took Maths can add B.Des by sitting the Creative Ability Test alongside the General Ability Test.

03 The seat arithmetic nobody puts on a poster

This is the number that should shape your strategy, and it is public in every official brochure. It is just never put side by side.

245	3,423	9	5,076
UCEED B.Des seats	**NIFT B.Des seats**	**NID seats per discipline**	**Total NIFT seats**
Across all 7 IITs, 2026-27 matrix	Regular plus state domicile, 2027	Per campus discipline, 2027	All programmes, all 20 campuses

UCEED's entire national intake is 245 seats. IIT Bombay takes 37. IIT Indore takes 16. NIFT, by contrast, lists 3,423 B.Des seats before you count its 591 B.F.Tech seats, 275 M.Des seats and 719 M.F.M seats.

Read that again, because it changes what these exams are for. UCEED is a prestige lottery with a small, well-defined prize. NIFT is a large, distributed system with a real chance of a seat. NID sits at the narrow end: nine seats per discipline at each campus, which is why NID's shortlist is capped at 2.5 times the available seats per category.

The practical consequence: nobody sensible prepares for one of these exams. You register for all three, you let one preparation serve all three, and you treat UCEED as the bonus rather than the plan. Chapter 24 builds exactly that shared preparation.

04 The money map

Design education in India is not cheap, and the entrance fees are the smallest line in the budget. Here is the honest picture before you commit.

Cost	UCEED route	NIFT route	NID route
Application fee (general)	Rs. 4,000	Rs. 2,000 (Rs. 3,000 for two programmes)	Rs. 3,000
Application fee (SC/ST/PwD, female)	Rs. 2,000	Rs. 500	Rs. 500 to Rs. 2,000
Late fee if you miss the window	Rs. 500	Rs. 5,000	No late window
Seat acceptance / admission payment	Rs. 65,000 (Rs. 20,000 SC/ST/PwD)	As per campus admission schedule	As per NID counselling
Course fee, indicative	IIT B.Des fee structure is published per institute closer to admission	About Rs. 14.09 lakh over four years, per NIFT's 2026-27 fee circular	Published by each NID campus

Two lines deserve a second look.

First, NIFT's late fee is Rs. 5,000 on top of a Rs. 2,000 application fee. Missing 16 November 2026 does not cost you a small penalty - it costs you two and a half times the application fee for the privilege of five extra days.

Second, UCEED's seat acceptance fee is Rs. 65,000, of which Rs. 5,000 is a processing fee that is never refunded. If you accept a seat in April and withdraw by 7 July 2027, you get Rs. 60,000 back. If you withdraw later than that, you are governed by the admitting institute's own refund policy, which you should read before you pay, not after.

The cheapest mistake in this entire process is the application fee. The most expensive is a seat you accept and then abandon.

PART TWO

The deadline map

Registration windows are not simultaneous, and the order is not negotiable. Here is the sequence, verified from the official portals on 31 October 2026.

05 The master calendar

Date	What happens	Which exam
31 Oct 2026	Regular-fee registration closes	UCEED and CEED
1 to 6 Nov 2026, 5:00 pm	Late-fee registration only (Rs. 500 extra)	UCEED and CEED
16 Nov 2026	Last date for online application at the normal fee	NIFTEE
21 Nov 2026	Last date with Rs. 5,000 late fee	NIFTEE
22 to 25 Nov 2026	Correction window, online only	NIFTEE
30 Nov 2026, 11:59 pm	Application closes, no late window	NID DAT
1 to 3 Dec 2026	Application edit window	NID DAT
10 Dec 2026, 4:00 pm	Prelims admit card released	NID DAT

Date	What happens	Which exam
20 Dec 2026	DAT Prelims	NID DAT
21 Dec 2026	Advance city intimation slip	NIFTEE
1 Jan 2027, 1:00 pm	Admit card download opens	UCEED and CEED
4 Jan 2027	Admit card released	NIFTEE
10 Jan 2027	Entrance examination	NIFTEE
17 Jan 2027, 9:00 am to 12:00 noon	Entrance examination	UCEED and CEED

The calendar forces one conclusion. Between today and 30 November you must complete three separate registrations on three separate portals, each with its own login system, its own document upload rules and its own fee. Nothing about them is shared. UCEED and CEED share the IIT Bombay office and the same deadline; NIFT runs through the National Testing Agency's MeriPehchaan single sign-on; NID runs its own portal at admissions.nid.edu.

06 UCEED 2027, step by step

UCEED is conducted by IIT Bombay under the UCEED-CEED Implementation Committee. Registration happens only through uceed.iitb.ac.in - there is no offline route and no agent route.

1. Create a login on the registration portal. Use an email address and mobile number you will still control in July 2027, because every subsequent notice, allotment letter and refund instruction goes there.
2. Confirm you meet all three eligibility criteria at once: age, number of attempts, and first appearance at Class XII in 2026 or 2027. Failing any one of them cancels your registration later, with no refund.
3. Enter your category exactly as your certificate states it. The brochure is blunt: the category in the database is final and will not be changed after registration. OBC candidates must be on the central list at ncbc.nic.in - a state-list OBC who is not on the central list must register as General.
4. Upload your documents in the specified formats. Incomplete forms are rejected summarily and the registration is treated as invalid.
5. Pay the fee: Rs. 4,000 for the general category, Rs. 2,000 for female candidates of any category and for SC, ST and PwD candidates. Bank charges are extra.
6. Download and keep the confirmation. Registration is not complete until payment is recorded.

> **The certificate date trap**
> For appearing in UCEED 2027, your EWS or OBC-NCL certificate must have been issued on or after 1 April 2026. For the B.Des admission stage in 2027-28, the EWS certificate must be issued on or after 1 April 2027. A certificate that is valid for the exam can still be too old for admission. If yours was issued in early 2026, plan to renew it before the counselling rounds open in April 2027.

The exam itself is three hours, in English only, worth 300 marks. Part A is a computer-based test of 200 marks in two hours. Part B is 100 marks of drawing and design aptitude in one hour, answered in a booklet the invigilator hands you 30 minutes before the exam starts. Both parts are compulsory. There is no re-evaluation, no re-grading and no re-totalling of either part.

Results are declared on 6 March 2027 and the score card downloads from 10 March. It is valid only for admission in the 2027-28 academic year. Shortlisting based on Part A is announced on 4 February 2027,

before the full result.

07 NIFTEE 2027, step by step

NIFT's entrance examination is now run by the National Testing Agency on NIFT's behalf, through exams.nta.nic.in/niftee. That changes the mechanics: you will register through MeriPehchaan, the government single sign-on, and you will complete Aadhaar-based e-KYC with a live photograph.

1 Register through MeriPehchaan and note the application number. It is used for both test components and for all later correspondence.

2 Choose your programme deliberately. There are separate application links for regular UG and PG, for NLEA, for the Artisan category, for PhD and for international applicants. Choosing the wrong link is the most common irreversible error here.

3 Decide whether you are applying for one programme or two. Applying for B.Des and B.F.Tech together costs Rs. 3,000 instead of Rs. 2,000, and gives you a second merit list. For a general-category candidate this is usually worth it.

4 Upload a photograph of 10 to 200 KB as JPG, a signature of 10 to 50 KB as JPG, and a disability or UDID certificate of 50 to 300 KB as PDF where applicable. Complete the live photograph step - the form will not submit without it.

5 Pay by debit card, credit card, UPI or net banking, then download the confirmation page. The application is confirmed only when the payment is received.

6 Use the correction window from 22 to 25 November 2026 for anything you got wrong. After it closes, nothing can be changed, at any stage.

The two test components run on different systems on the same day. The General Ability Test is a computer-based test. The Creative Ability Test is a pen-and-paper test. The GAT paper is bilingual, Hindi and English, and you answer in the medium you declared in the form. The CAT is answered by hand.

08 NID DAT 2027, step by step

NID's admission runs on its own portal, admissions.nid.edu, and one application covers both the prelims and the mains. There is no late-fee extension: the window closes at 11:59 pm on 30 November 2026.

1 Sign up selecting programme of study, nationality and category. Your name, date of birth, email and mobile number cannot be changed later, so get them right the first time.

2 Complete the application form and upload photograph, signature, category certificate where applicable, and passport for overseas applicants.

3 Pay the fee: Rs. 3,000 for General, General-EWS and OBC-NCL; Rs. 2,000 for female candidates except SC, ST and PwD; Rs. 1,500 for SC and ST; Rs. 500 for PwD and third gender; US$ 125 for overseas candidates.

4 Choose your test centre. Seventeen cities host the prelims. You can change it only during the 1 to 3 December edit window.

5 Print the auto-generated application form. NID treats the application as complete only when you can view and download that form.

What NID says about coaching

NID's own registration page carries an unusual line: the institute does not encourage coaching classes for its admission test and has not authorised or franchised anyone to conduct such classes. It asks applicants not to fall prey to such claims. Take that at face value - it also means the exam rewards observation and drawing practice over memorised content, which is exactly what Chapters 24 to 28 build.

09 CEED 2027, in brief

CEED is for graduates, not school students, and it shares UCEED's calendar: registration from 1 to 31 October 2026, late registration to 6 November, exam on 17 January 2027 from 9:00 am to 12:00 noon, result on 3 March 2027.

The eligibility is a graduate degree or diploma of at least three years after 10+2, or a final-year candidate appearing by July 2027, or the five-year Government Diploma in Art taken after Class 10. Part A is objective and computer-based. Part B is five questions testing design, drawing and writing skills.

The scoring is where CEED differs from every other exam in this book, and it should change how you practise.

CEED final score = 0.25 x Part A + 0.75 x Part B

Three-quarters of your CEED score is drawing and writing. A candidate who aces the objective paper and draws averagely will lose to a candidate who is merely good at Part A and excellent on paper. If you are preparing for CEED, your sketchbook is not a supplement to your preparation - it is your preparation.

The CEED score is valid for one year from the result date, and qualifying does not guarantee admission anywhere. Each of the 11 participating institutes runs its own admission process afterwards, and some add their own tests or interviews.

10 Twelve registration errors that end a candidature

None of these are exotic. All of them are permanent.

1. Registering under a category your certificate does not support. UCEED will not change it, and a false document cancels admission even after you have joined.
2. Using a state OBC-NCL certificate where only the central list counts, in both UCEED and NIFT.
3. Uploading a photograph outside the size range. NTA's limits are strict: 10 to 200 KB for NIFT, and UCEED rejects invalid uploads outright.
4. Skipping the live photograph step on the NIFT form. The form will not complete.
5. Missing the NIFT correction window. After 25 November 2026 the application is frozen.
6. Choosing the NLEA or Artisan application link on NIFT's portal when you want regular admission.
7. Declaring the wrong answer medium on NIFT. The GAT is bilingual, but you answer in the medium you declared.
8. Assuming a gap year preserves UCEED eligibility. It does not: the attempt must follow a first Class XII appearance in 2026 or 2027.
9. Assuming NID has a late window. It does not.

10 Leaving the application to the last hour. All three portals close automatically at a fixed time, and payment gateways fail under load. UCEED's brochure says plainly that it will not be possible to register after 5:00 pm on 6 November because the portal closes automatically.

11 Paying into a third party's account. UCEED, NID and NTA all collect only through their own portals. Any 'agent' offering to complete your form for a fee is a risk with no upside.

12 Losing the confirmation page. It is your only proof if a payment is later disputed.

PART THREE

UCEED, decoded

UCEED is the most misunderstood of the four. People treat it as a harder NIFT - a bigger multiple-choice paper with drawing bolted on. It is not. It is a two-part exam where one part is a gate and the other is a ranking, and the gate is failed by more candidates than the ranking is.

11 The paper, in full

	Part A	Part B
Marks	200	100
Time	2 hours	1 hour
Mode	Computer-based test	Drawing on a booklet provided in the hall
Structure	Three sections, 57 questions	Two questions: Sketching 50 marks, Design Aptitude 50 marks
Language	English only	English only

Part A breaks down into three sections with three different marking systems. This is the detail that separates a prepared candidate from a busy one.

Section	Type	Questions	Correct	Wrong	Section total
1	Numerical Answer Type (NAT)	14	+4	0	56
2	Multiple Select Question (MSQ)	15	+4 with partial credit	-1	60
3	Multiple Choice Question (MCQ)	28	+3	-0.71	84
Total		57			200

Note what is missing: there is no negative marking on NAT. Fourteen questions carry 56 marks and cost you nothing to attempt. Leaving a NAT blank is the only decision in this exam with a guaranteed loss attached.

12 The marking maths that decides your Part A

Most advice on negative marking is folk wisdom. The numbers here are small enough to compute exactly, so let us compute them.

MCQ first. Three marks for a correct answer, minus 0.71 for a wrong one, four options. If you know nothing and guess, your expected score is 0.25 x 3 minus 0.75 x 0.71, which is 0.75 minus 0.53 - about plus 0.22

marks per question. Guessing is mildly profitable. If you can eliminate one option, the expected score rises to about plus 0.53. If you can eliminate two, it is plus 1.29.

That is a real conclusion: on UCEED MCQs, attempt every question you can narrow to two options, and guess even when you cannot narrow it at all. Twenty-eight MCQs at a positive expected value is worth several marks across the paper.

MSQ is the opposite, and this is where candidates bleed. Partial credit runs +4 for all correct options with none wrong, +3 for three of four when all four are correct, +2 for two correct when three or more are correct, and +1 for a single correct option when two or more are correct. Anything else - including picking one right option and one wrong one - scores minus 1.

Suppose you are certain two options are correct and unsure about a third. Selecting just your two certain options scores +2. Selecting three and being wrong on the third scores minus 1. You gain one mark if you are right and lose three if you are wrong, so you need to be more than 75 per cent confident to justify adding it. You will rarely be that confident. Stop at what you know.

Suppose you are certain of only one option. Selecting it scores +1. Adding a second gains one more if correct and loses two if wrong, so you need to be better than two-in-three. Same discipline applies.

> **The MSQ rule to memorise**
> Never add an option you are not sure of. On MSQ, the partial-credit structure pays you for certainty and punishes curiosity. Mark only what you would defend.

13 Part A's six question families

The syllabus is published and it is short: visualisation and spatial reasoning, practical and scientific knowledge, observation and design sensitivity, environment and society, analytical and logical reasoning, language, and creativity. That list is exhaustive as a description of topic areas but useless as a study plan. Here is what each one actually looks like on the paper.

Visualisation and spatial reasoning. Folding, unfolding, rotating, mirroring, cutting, assembling. A flat net is shown; which solid does it make. A shape is rotated; which option matches. These are the questions you can train fastest, because the underlying skill is mental rotation and it improves with volume, not theory. Twenty minutes a day on nets and rotation, for three weeks, moves this section more than any other single habit.

Practical and scientific knowledge. How everyday objects work and why. Why a pressure cooker has a weight on the lid. What a given mechanism does. What happens when you push here. The exam assumes a curious person, not a physics topper. If you have never wondered how a door latch works, start wondering now.

Observation and design sensitivity. Two images differ in five places; find them. An object is shown from one angle; what does the back look like. A product is shown; what is wrong with it. This is the section that rewards the observation journal in Chapter 27 more than any mock test.

Environment and society. Design in context: accessibility, sustainability, Indian material culture, how people actually use things. Questions here are often verbal rather than visual, and they reward a candidate who reads a newspaper rather than one who memorises facts.

Analytical and logical reasoning. Standard reasoning with a design flavour - sequences, deductions, data interpretation. Treat it as a speed section. If a question takes more than 90 seconds, mark and move.

Language and creativity. English comprehension, plus verbal and non-verbal analogy: which word pairs with this the way that pairs with that; which symbol completes the metaphor. The language is standard English, not literary English.

14 Part B is a gate, and it is the gate most people fail

Here is the single most useful fact in this book, and it is buried on page 33 of the UCEED brochure.

> **Part B has its own qualifying cut-off**
> OPEN 15 out of 100. OBC-NCL and EWS 13.5. SC, ST and PwD 7.5. A candidate qualifies for a UCEED rank only if the Part B score is at or above the cut-off for their category - regardless of the Part A score.

Read the consequence. A candidate scoring 190 out of 200 in Part A and 14 out of 100 in Part B receives no rank at all. Not a low rank. No rank. The Part A brilliance is discarded because a separate gate was not cleared.

Now consider how most candidates prepare. Part A is 57 questions, objectively marked, with answer keys published on 19 January and mock tests available everywhere. Part B is two subjective questions marked by two independent examiners, with no model answer published and no re-evaluation permitted. Part A is easy to practise and easy to feel progress on. Part B is neither.

So the effort distribution inverts: candidates spend most of their time on the part they can measure, and the part that can disqualify them gets whatever is left. If you take one thing from this chapter, take this - book a fixed Part B slot in your week and protect it like an exam.

The two Part B questions are worth 50 marks each. One is sketching: draw products, people or scenes in proportion, with good line quality, composition, perspective and shading. The other is design aptitude: respond practically and appropriately to a problem or situation with ingenuity and empathy. The second one is not a drawing test. It is a thinking test with a drawing attached.

The marking is a double-blind system - your identity is not visible to the examiners - and there is no re-evaluation, re-grading or re-totalling of either part. What you draw in that hour is final.

15 The 60-minute Part B drill

This is a repeatable weekly session. Run it every week from now until January, and time it.

1. Minutes 0 to 5: read both questions and write a two-line intent for each. What is this object, who is it for, what does it solve.
2. Minutes 5 to 25: question one. Ten minutes on construction - a light frame, the big shapes, the proportions - then ten minutes on line weight, detail and shading. Do not start with detail.
3. Minutes 25 to 30: stand back and fix the single worst thing. One fix, not five.
4. Minutes 30 to 52: question two. Sketch three thumbnails in six minutes, choose one in one minute, then spend fifteen minutes making it legible: labels, arrows, a human figure for scale, one clear improvement over the obvious solution.
5. Minutes 52 to 58: annotate. Four short notes explaining why, not what.
6. Minutes 58 to 60: check that your name and roll number are in the right place and nowhere else. Any identifying mark on the drawing is a disqualification risk.

The mistake in this drill is almost always the same. Candidates spend 50 of the 60 minutes on question one because it feels like drawing, and then rush question two, which carries the same 50 marks. Split the hour before you start, not after.

PART FOUR

NIFT, decoded

NIFT is the exam where strategy beats talent, because its weightage is published and almost nobody acts on it.

16 Where the NIFT rank is actually won

Component	Weight in final merit	Format
General Ability Test (GAT)	30 per cent	Computer-based, 100 questions, 120 minutes, bilingual
Creative Ability Test (CAT)	50 per cent	Pen and paper, 3 questions, 180 minutes
Situation Test	20 per cent	Hands-on model making for shortlisted candidates, March or April 2027

The Creative Ability Test alone is worth more than the General Ability Test and the Situation Test combined. The GAT, which is the part with past papers, mock series and coaching batches, is the smallest single component.

Make that concrete. Two candidates, scores expressed out of 100 so the weightage arithmetic is visible.

Candidate	GAT (30%)	CAT (50%)	Situation Test (20%)	Final
A - drilled the GAT	90	40	50	57.0
B - drew instead	55	75	70	68.0

Candidate B is thirty-five marks weaker on the objective paper and wins by eleven. Candidate A did the thing that felt like studying. Candidate B did the thing that the weightage rewards.

The lesson is not to ignore the GAT - 30 per cent is 30 per cent, and the GAT is also the cheapest 30 per cent to secure because it is objectively marked. The lesson is to stop letting the GAT eat the calendar. If your week has six hours of design preparation, two go to the GAT and four go to the CAT and the Situation Test.

17 The GAT: 100 questions in 120 minutes

One hundred questions, one mark each, minus 0.25 for a wrong answer, no marks for unattempted. That is 72 seconds per question, including reading time. The paper is bilingual, and you answer in the medium you declared on the form.

The published components are quantitative ability, communication ability and English comprehension, analytical and logical ability, and general knowledge and current affairs. NIFT states that the number of questions in each section may vary year to year, so do not build a plan around a fixed section count. Build one around speed.

The quantitative ability list is unusually narrow and worth reading literally: addition, multiplication, division, fractions, percentage, rate of interest, work and task, ratio and proportion, distance. This is arithmetic

reasoning, not mathematics. If you are revising calculus for NIFT's GAT, you are revising the wrong subject.

Communication ability is day-to-day English: synonyms, antonyms, one-word substitutes, idioms and phrases, correct spellings, and comprehension of a passage. General knowledge and current affairs is what its name says.

On guessing: with four options and minus 0.25, a blind guess is worth about plus 0.06 marks - barely positive. Eliminate one option and it becomes plus 0.17. So attempt everything you can narrow, and treat the last thirty seconds of the paper as a sweep for anything left entirely blank.

18 The CAT: three questions, three hours

The Creative Ability Test is three questions in 180 minutes, answered by hand. NIFT's own description of what it measures is precise: intuitive ability, power of observation in concept development, design ability, and the creative and innovative use of colour and illustration skills.

Three things follow from that description.

- Intuitive ability and observation are tested before technique. An honest, well-observed drawing of an ordinary thing beats an elaborate drawing of an invented one.
- Concept development is a named criterion. That means a page showing three ideas, with the chosen one developed and the other two visibly rejected, scores better than one polished idea with no visible thinking.
- Colour and illustration are explicitly rewarded. Monochrome pencil work leaves marks on the table.

One rule is absolute: candidates who disclose their identity - writing personal details, a coaching centre's name or logo, or placing any identification mark on the answer sheet - are disqualified and their result is not declared. This has ended candidatures. Keep every margin clean.

19 The Situation Test: seven parameters, one model

Shortlisted B.Des candidates go to a test centre in March or April 2027 and are given a situation and a set of materials. They build a model and write a concept note. No additional material is provided or allowed - what is in the kit is what you have.

The model is assessed on seven published parameters. They are worth reading as a marking scheme, because they tell you where to spend your two hours.

1. Space visualisation - does the model read as a three-dimensional thing with a clear inside, outside and scale.
2. Innovative and creative use of the given material - is the material transformed, or merely assembled.
3. Composition of elements - is the arrangement deliberate, or is everything in the middle.
4. Colour scheme - is colour used to organise the model, or scattered across it.
5. Construction skill - does it stand up, and are the joins clean.
6. Finesse of the model - the finish: cut edges, symmetry, no stray glue.
7. Overall presentation - the whole thing, including how the write-up supports it.

Two of those seven - finesse and construction - are pure craft and can be trained with a pair of scissors and a stack of chart paper. Two more - composition and colour - are trainable in a sketchbook. That is four of seven parameters available to anyone willing to practise, without any natural drawing talent.

The write-up is not optional and it must be in English. NIFT states that no marks are given for a write-up in any other language. It is also the only place you can explain intent, so treat it as 15 minutes of your time, not five.

Identity disclosure disqualifies here too, on the model, the design or the write-up. Evaluation happens on the spot by a jury and the model is not preserved.

20 The B.F.Tech fork

B.F.Tech is the programme most candidates overlook, and for a Maths student it is a second, cheaper route into NIFT. The structure is different: the General Ability Test has two sections - Section A of 100 questions in 120 minutes and Section B of 50 questions in 60 minutes - and there is no Creative Ability Test. The weightage is 30 per cent for Section A and 70 per cent for Section B, followed by a Technical Ability Test in April 2027 for NLEA candidates.

There are 591 B.F.Tech seats in the 2027 regular matrix. If your Maths is decent and your drawing is not, this is the honest choice, and the merit list is separate from B.Des so you are not competing with the sketchers.

And if you have Maths and want both, you can apply for both programmes for Rs. 3,000 and sit the CAT alongside the GAT. NIFT generates separate Common Merit Ranks for each. That is the highest-value Rs. 1,000 in this entire process.

PART FIVE

NID, decoded

NID is the smallest door in this book - nine seats per discipline - and the earliest exam. It is also the one where the format is least like the others, which means preparation for UCEED and NIFT transfers to it only partly.

21 DAT Prelims: a paper test, on 20 December 2026

The preliminary test is a paper-and-pencil test, conducted at the same time on the same day across all centres, and it is common to every NID. It is in English only. The questions may involve text and visuals, and the duration is stated on the admit card rather than fixed in the handbook - which is itself a reason to read the admit card carefully when it appears on 10 December.

> **The Prelims score does not carry forward**
> NID is explicit: the Prelims score is used only to shortlist candidates for the Mains and is not carried forward as any weightage. Shortlisting is at 2.5 times the available seats per category. So the Prelims is a gate, not a score you bank. Do not spend a month optimising a mark that stops mattering on 16 March.

That single fact changes your preparation for NID. There is no benefit to being first in the Prelims - you need to be inside the top 2.5 times the seats in your category, and then the slate is wiped. The effort belongs in the Mains, where the actual merit list is built.

Seventeen cities host the Prelims: Ahmedabad, Bengaluru, Bhopal, Bhubaneswar, Chandigarh, Chennai, Dehradun, Hyderabad, Jaipur, Jorhat, Kochi, Kolkata, Lucknow, Mumbai, Nagpur, New Delhi and Patna. A city may have more than one centre, and NID reserves the right to allot a centre that is not your first choice.

22 DAT Mains: two tests, one merit list

Shortlisted candidates sit the Mains, which has two parts: a Studio Sensitivity Test and an In-Person Sensitivity Test. The dates are announced later, and the final merit list is built on the Mains score alone.

The Studio Sensitivity Test is the model-making, material-handling, drawing-and-thinking test. The In-Person Sensitivity Test is a live interaction. Both reward the same underlying quality, which NID's own handbook frames as sensitivity - to material, to space, to a problem, and to people.

Practically, this is why NID candidates who have only drilled multiple-choice papers do badly. There is no multiple-choice paper. The preparation in Chapters 24 to 28 - observation journal, drawing drills, material practice - is the preparation for NID.

23 Nine seats, and how to choose a discipline

At NID Ahmedabad, Gandhinagar and Bengaluru, the 2027 intake is nine seats per discipline. That is the number against which your effort is measured, and it should inform which discipline you name.

Stream	Discipline examples	Campus
Industrial Design	Product Design, Ceramic and Glass Design, Transportation and Automobile Design	Ahmedabad, Gandhinagar
Communication Design	Graphic Design, Animation Film Design, Film and Video Communication, Interaction Design	Ahmedabad
Spatial Experience	Exhibition Design, Furniture and Interior Design, Design for Retail Experience	Ahmedabad, Bengaluru
Textile and Apparel	Textile Design, Apparel Design, Lifestyle Accessory Design	Ahmedabad, Gandhinagar

Nine seats means the difference between the most and least contested discipline in your category can be several hundred ranks. Choose on the basis of what you would actually do for four years, not on which sounds easiest - but do check the intake at each campus before you commit, because NID Andhra Pradesh, Assam, Haryana and Madhya Pradesh publish their own discipline lists and seat counts on their own institute websites.

Reservation follows the standard pattern: 10 per cent GEN-EWS, 27 per cent OBC-NCL, 15 per cent SC, 7.5 per cent ST, with 5 per cent PwD applied across categories. Overseas candidates get a separate supernumerary pool of 15 per cent. Seat allotment follows merit, category and the preferences you submit, and a rank in the merit list does not guarantee a seat in the discipline you want.

One more thing worth knowing: after the Mains results, you must submit a separate online application for admission. Candidates who assume the entrance application covers admission, and skip it, become ineligible for seat allotment across every NID.

PART SIX

The eleven weeks

From today to 17 January 2027 is eleven weeks. That is enough to move a genuine beginner into contention and enough for a prepared candidate to waste. What follows is one plan that serves all three undergraduate exams, because the skills overlap far more than the syllabi suggest.

24 The week-by-week plan

Each week has one primary focus and one non-negotiable output. The output is the part that matters - a plan you can complete without producing anything is a reading list, not preparation.

Week	Dates	Primary focus	Non-negotiable output
1	2 to 8 Nov	Register for UCEED and CEED before 6 November. Start the observation journal.	Two registrations completed, seven journal entries
2	9 to 15 Nov	Register for NIFT. Begin Part B sketching: line and proportion.	NIFT application submitted, six 20-minute sketches
3	16 to 22 Nov	Register for NID. Spatial reasoning: nets, folds, rotations.	NID application submitted, 60 net and rotation problems
4	23 to 29 Nov	NID application closes 30 November. Object drawing from life.	Application printed, ten object drawings
5	30 Nov to 6 Dec	GAT speed work: quant and English under timer.	Two full GAT papers, error log started
6	7 to 13 Dec	CAT practice: three questions, 180 minutes, timed.	One full CAT paper, three thumbnails per question
7	14 to 20 Dec	NID Prelims week. Taper, do not cram.	Exam written on 20 December
8	21 to 27 Dec	Situation Test craft: paper, straw, clay, foil, thread.	Five models from a 90-minute kit
9	28 Dec to 3 Jan	Part B double sessions: sketching plus design aptitude.	Four timed Part B papers
10	4 to 10 Jan	NIFT exam week. GAT and CAT revision only.	NIFT written on 10 January
11	11 to 17 Jan	UCEED week. Part A light, Part B protected.	UCEED written on 17 January

Two structural decisions are built into that table. NID sits in week 7, so the six weeks before it are shared preparation rather than NID-specific drilling - which is possible because NID's prelims rewards observation and drawing, the same two skills the other exams need. And the last two weeks are exam weeks, not learning weeks. Nothing new enters after week 9.

25 The daily ninety minutes

Long study sessions are a poor fit for these exams because almost nothing is memorised. A short, daily, timed block beats a weekend marathon, and it is the only version that survives school or college.

Block	Minutes	What you do
Warm-up	10	Observation journal: pick one object in the room and draw it from three angles, no erasing

Block	Minutes	What you do
Skill	30	One topic from the week's focus, timed, with the clock visible
Draw	35	Part B or CAT practice: one sketching question or one design aptitude question, in full
Review	15	Look at yesterday's work, write one line on what was worst, fix only that

Ninety minutes, six days a week, for eleven weeks, is roughly one hundred hours. That is more than most candidates at these exams will do, and it is achievable alongside a full school timetable.

The review block is the one people skip and the one that produces the gains. Drawing improves through correction, not through repetition. Fifteen minutes of looking honestly at yesterday's page is worth more than another thirty minutes of drawing the same thing badly.

26 Drawing: the five things that get marked

Both UCEED's Part B and NIFT's CAT name their criteria explicitly. Stripped to essentials, five skills are being assessed, and they can be trained separately.

Line. Confidence and consistency. A single clean line beats a hairy one made of forty small strokes. The drill is simple and dull: fill a page with straight lines, then circles, then curves, drawn from the shoulder, without lifting the pencil to correct. Ten minutes a day for two weeks fixes most line quality problems.

Proportion. The relationship between parts. The classic failure is drawing what you know rather than what you see - a mug drawn with a handle that is too big because the handle is what makes it a mug. The drill is comparative measurement: hold a pencil at arm's length, mark the height of the object on it, then measure every other dimension against that mark.

Perspective. Why things get smaller. You do not need formal vanishing-point construction for these exams; you need to be consistent. If the top of a box recedes, the bottom must recede at the same rate. Draw boxes from imagination in one-, two- and three-point perspective until the inconsistency stops being invisible to you.

Composition. Where things sit on the page. The default beginner layout is one object in the centre of the page with a lot of empty space. Better: decide the frame first, place the subject off-centre, let one element break the frame, and leave deliberate negative space. Composition is the cheapest marks in the whole exam because it costs no drawing skill.

Shading. Light as information. One light source, decided before you start, applied consistently. Three values are enough: light, mid, shadow. Candidates who shade with six values usually have no light source at all, just texture.

27 The observation journal

Ten minutes a day, one page, no erasing. It is the single highest-return habit in this book because three of the four exams test observation directly, and because it is the one habit that cannot be crammed.

What goes on the page: one object, drawn. Not a beautiful object - the object in front of you. A chair leg. A hinge. A pressure cooker weight. A folded shirt. A vegetable. Below the drawing, three lines: what it is made of, how it is made, and one thing about it that is badly designed.

That third line is the part that earns marks. UCEED's design sensitivity questions and NIFT's CAT both reward a candidate who notices that a thing could be better, and the noticing is trainable. After three weeks of writing that line daily, you will start seeing the flaws in everything, which is exactly the disposition these exams are screening for.

28 Mocks, and how to review them

The mock test is a diagnostic, not a rehearsal. A candidate who does twelve mocks and reviews none improves less than a candidate who does four and reviews each one properly.

How many. Two full GAT papers, one full CAT paper, four timed Part B papers, and three or four full-length UCEED Part A papers. That is enough. More than that and you are practising speed you already have.

How to review. Build one error log, on paper or in a spreadsheet, with four columns: question, why I got it wrong, the rule I should have applied, and the date I will re-attempt it. Sort the reasons into three buckets - did not know, knew but misread, knew but ran out of time. The buckets matter more than the questions.

> **The three buckets tell you what to fix**
> Most wrong answers are 'knew but misread'. That is not a knowledge problem, so more studying will not fix it; a slower first pass and a habit of underlining the actual question will. 'Ran out of time' is a pacing problem, fixed by section budgets. Only 'did not know' is a content problem - and it is usually the smallest bucket.

Re-attempt the logged questions after seven days, not the next day. Next-day re-attempts test memory of the answer. Seven-day re-attempts test whether the rule stuck.

PART SEVEN

After the exam

The exam is the easy part to understand and the hard part to execute. Everything after it is paperwork, deadlines and money - and it is where candidates who cleared the exam still lose the seat.

29 UCEED to a B.Des seat: five rounds and three traps

Qualifying in UCEED is not admission. You must apply separately for B.Des through the common application form on the IIT Bombay admissions portal, and you must do it in the window that opens in March 2027. The application needs your score card, your Class XII marksheet, and category, PwD or OCI/PIO documents where applicable.

Round	Announced	Seat acceptance payment by	Withdrawal window
I	21 Apr 2027	29 Apr 2027, 6:00 pm	30 Apr to 11 May 2027, 6:00 pm
II	19 May 2027	27 May 2027, 6:00 pm	28 May to 9 Jun 2027, 6:00 pm
III	14 Jun 2027	18 Jun 2027, 6:00 pm	19 to 22 Jun 2027, 6:00 pm
IV	25 Jun 2027	3 Jul 2027, 6:00 pm	4 to 7 Jul 2027, 6:00 pm
V	9 Jul 2027	13 Jul 2027, 6:00 pm	No withdrawal after this round

Seat acceptance is Rs. 65,000 for GEN, EWS and OBC-NCL candidates and Rs. 20,000 for SC, ST and PwD candidates, including a Rs. 5,000 processing fee that is not refundable in any circumstance. You pay it once - if you accept a seat and later move up, you do not pay again.

Trap one: the freeze and float choice. If you are allotted your first-choice institute, you may only freeze or decline. Decline ends your participation. If you are allotted a second to seventh choice, you may freeze or float. Float means you keep the seat but stay in the running for a higher preference - and if a higher preference is later offered, the seat you accepted is automatically forfeited. That is not a penalty; it is the mechanism. But it means you should never float towards an institute you would not actually attend.

Trap two: the refund cliff. Withdraw by 7 July 2027 at 6:00 pm and you get Rs. 60,000 back on the Rs. 65,000, or Rs. 15,000 on the Rs. 20,000. Withdraw after that and your refund follows the admitting institute's policy, which is usually worse. There are no withdrawal options at all after the final round is announced.

Trap three: the spot round that does not exist. There are no spot admission rounds at the IITs after counselling closes. IIITDM Jabalpur may conduct an institutional spot round if seats remain, but you cannot plan around it.

Also remember that the float option stays active only until the payment end date of Round IV. After that, whatever you hold is what you keep.

30 NIFT after the paper

NIFT's Stage 1 result is declared on the NTA and NIFT websites in February or March 2027. Shortlisted B.Des candidates then attend a Situation Test at a test centre in March or April 2027, where the model carries 20 per cent of the final merit. Final results are declared in the first week of May 2027, and NIFT conducts seat allocation in May and June.

NLEA candidates face a longer sequence: the Studio Test, a Personal Interview and document verification in April 2027. B.F.Tech candidates sit a Technical Ability Test instead of a Studio Test.

Two things to have ready before the Situation Test, because both are checked: your admit card and a photo ID, and a clear understanding that no outside material enters the hall. Candidates who arrive with their own craft supplies are not accommodated.

31 NID after the prelims

The B.Des prelims result is declared on 16 March 2027 at 4:00 pm, with the M.Des result earlier, on 16 February 2027. There is a re-totalling window for the prelims answer booklet on 16 and 17 March. The category certificate edit window runs from 16 to 28 February 2027 - which is before the B.Des result, so if your certificate needs correcting, do it in February, not in March.

The Mains dates are announced later. After the Mains result, you submit a separate online application for admission. Then comes counselling, fee payment and physical verification of documents. If the allotment is conducted in person, you must attend with the original documents - failing to report forfeits the seat to the next candidate in your category.

32 If it does not work

Three of these routes are real, official and underused. None require you to wait a year.

NIFT lateral entry. NLEA takes diploma holders into the third semester of a B.Des or B.F.Tech programme. The tentative 2027 availability is 401 seats, split across disciplines - 80 in Fashion Design, 72 in Fashion Communication, 68 in Textile Design, 64 in Accessory Design, 59 in Apparel Production, 35 in Knitwear Design, 15 in Leather Design and 8 in Fashion Interiors. These seats are what remains after NIFT's Student Permanent Transfer process, so the number is indicative rather than fixed. The route requires a three or four year diploma recognised by AICTE, AIU, UGC or a State Board of Technical Education in a related field.

The Artisan category. NIFT reserves seats for artisans and wards of artisans holding a valid Artisan Card from the Development Commissioner (Handicraft) or (Handlooms), Ministry of Textiles. The application window is much longer - to 31 January 2027 - and the selection is an Artisan Skill Test plus a Personal Interview in April 2027, not the regular entrance. The Artisan Skill Test is marked out of 100, with 70 for the model and write-up and 30 for the interview.

Result-sharing institutes. UCEED's score was accepted by 47 other institutes in the 2026 cycle, including BITS Design School, FLAME University, Mahindra University, CEPT University, FDDI, Srishti Manipal, Shiv Nadar, Anant National University, MIT ID and Delhi Technological University. CEED's score reaches a similar list. A good UCEED rank that does not convert into an IIT seat can still convert into a strong design programme - which is a large part of why sitting the exam is worth it even at 245 seats.

And if you are taking the exam again: UCEED allows two attempts, in consecutive years. That is a hard limit, not a guideline. NIFT and NID do not impose an attempt limit, only age limits, which means a gap year is a genuine option for those two and not for UCEED.

PART EIGHT

Practice

A plan without material to practise on is a mood. Everything in this part is original - written for this book, not lifted from a past paper - so you can use it without wondering whether the answers are right.

Work through it with a clock, not with a highlighter. The value is in the attempt, then the explanation, then a second attempt a week later.

33 The next 48 hours

If you do nothing else this week, do these six things in this order. They take about three hours in total and they remove every deadline risk in this book.

1. Check the UCEED portal now. If regular registration has closed, the late window to 6 November 2026 at 5:00 pm is your last chance, and it costs Rs. 500 extra. The portal closes automatically at that time.
2. Check your Class XII year of first appearance. If it was 2025 or earlier, UCEED is closed to you and you should spend that hour on NIFT and NID instead.
3. Open the NIFT portal and confirm you are on the regular UG application link, not NLEA, Artisan or PhD.
4. Photograph and signature, correctly sized. NIFT wants 10 to 200 KB JPG for the photograph and 10 to 50 KB JPG for the signature. Do this once, save both files somewhere you will find them again, and reuse them on all three portals.
5. Ask your school for a certificate of appearance if you are still in Class 12 - some forms ask for it and schools take a week to issue one.
6. Put the three deadlines in your phone calendar with alarms at seven days and two days out. Not because you will forget the date, but because portals slow down in the final hours and you want to be finished before then.

34 UCEED Part A: twenty practice questions

Six numerical answer type, four multiple select, ten multiple choice. Do them in 35 minutes. Do not look at the key until the timer stops.

Numerical answer type. No options, no negative marking. Type a number.

1. A cube is painted on all six faces and then cut into 27 equal smaller cubes. How many of the small cubes have exactly two painted faces?
2. A square sheet of paper is folded in half three times. A single hole is then punched through all the layers. How many holes are visible when the sheet is fully unfolded?

3 In a row of 40 students, Anil is 12th from the left and Sunil is 17th from the right. How many students stand between them?

4 What is the angle between the hour hand and the minute hand of a clock at exactly 3:00, in degrees?

5 A rectangular box measures 12 cm by 8 cm by 6 cm. How many square centimetres of paper are needed to cover all six faces, ignoring overlaps?

6 The largest possible circle is cut from a square sheet of side 20 cm. Using pi as 3.14, what area of paper remains, in square centimetres?

Multiple select. One or more options may be correct. Full marks only when every correct option is chosen and nothing wrong is chosen.

7 Two rectangles have exactly the same area. Which of the following must be true? (a) They have the same perimeter. (b) They may have different perimeters. (c) If one of them is a square, its perimeter is the smallest possible among all rectangles with that area. (d) Their diagonals are equal.

8 Which of the following are examples of a lever? (a) Scissors. (b) A ramp. (c) A see-saw. (d) A wheelbarrow.

9 A 3 by 3 by 3 cube is painted red and cut into 27 unit cubes. Which of the following are true? (a) Eight cubes have three painted faces. (b) Six cubes have exactly one painted face. (c) Twelve cubes have exactly two painted faces. (d) One cube has no painted face.

10 Which of the following are true of a regular hexagon? (a) It has six lines of symmetry. (b) Each interior angle is 120 degrees. (c) Copies of it can tile a plane without gaps. (d) It has six diagonals.

Multiple choice. One correct option. Minus 0.71 for a wrong answer.

11 A net made of four rectangles and two squares folds into which solid? (a) Cube. (b) Cuboid. (c) Cylinder. (d) Triangular prism.

12 What comes next: 2, 6, 12, 20, 30, ? (a) 36. (b) 40. (c) 42. (d) 44.

13 How many edges does a triangular prism have? (a) 6. (b) 8. (c) 9. (d) 12.

14 Which is heavier: one kilogram of feathers or one kilogram of iron? (a) The feathers. (b) The iron. (c) They weigh the same. (d) It depends on the container.

15 One tap fills a tank in 6 hours and a second tap fills the same tank in 12 hours. Running together, how long do they take? (a) 3 hours. (b) 4 hours. (c) 4.5 hours. (d) 9 hours.

16 If SOUTH is written as TPVUI in a code, how is NORTH written? (a) MPSUI. (b) PSUI. (c) OPSUI. (d) PSUIQ.

17 Which of these has the greatest number of lines of symmetry? (a) A rectangle. (b) An equilateral triangle. (c) A square. (d) A regular hexagon.

18 SCISSORS is to CUT as NEEDLE is to: (a) thread. (b) sew. (c) sharp. (d) cloth.

19 A cylinder has a radius of 7 cm and a height of 10 cm. Using pi as 22/7, what is its volume in cubic centimetres? (a) 440. (b) 770. (c) 1,540. (d) 3,080.

20 Which of these words cannot be formed from the letters of DESIGNATION? (a) DESIGN. (b) NATION. (c) SIGNAL. (d) STONE.

35 Answer key, with the reasoning

Q	Answer	Why
1	12	The cubes with exactly two painted faces sit in the middle of each edge. Twelve edges, one such cube each.
2	8	Three halvings make eight layers, so one punch makes eight holes.
3	11	Sunil is 24th from the left (40 minus 17 plus 1). Positions 13 to 23 lie between them, which is eleven students.
4	90	The hour hand sits on 3 and the minute hand on 12. Each hour mark is 30 degrees.
5	432	Twice the sum of the three face-pair areas: 2 x (96 + 48 + 72).
6	86	The circle has radius 10, so 3.14 x 100 = 314. The square is 400. The remainder is 86.
7	b, c	Equal area does not fix the perimeter - a long thin rectangle has a larger one. Among rectangles of a given area, the square has the least perimeter.
8	a, c, d	A ramp is an inclined plane, not a lever.
9	a, b, c, d	All four are true. This is why the +3 partial-credit rule exists: sometimes all four options are correct, and choosing only three of them still earns marks.
10	a, b, c	A regular hexagon has nine diagonals, not six.
11	b	Four side rectangles and two square ends give a cuboid. A cube would need six equal squares.
12	c	The differences are 4, 6, 8 and 10, so the next difference is 12.
13	c	Three edges on each triangular face, three along the length.
14	c	Both are one kilogram. The question tests whether you read it carefully.
15	b	In one hour they fill one sixth plus one twelfth, which is one quarter of the tank.
16	b	Each letter moves forward one place: O to P, R to S, T to U, H to I.
17	d	A regular hexagon has six; a square four; an equilateral triangle three; a rectangle two.
18	b	The tool and its action, not the object it works with.
19	c	22/7 x 49 x 10.
20	c	SIGNAL needs an L, and DESIGNATION has none.

> **Score it the way the exam scores it**
>
> Count your MCQ attempts and your MCQ errors separately. Four wrong MCQs cost 2.84 marks - most of a correct NAT. If your error count is above six, your problem is not knowledge, it is the decision to attempt. Go back to Chapter 12 and apply the elimination rule rather than the guessing instinct.

36 Drawing prompts: what a strong answer contains

Eight prompts, to be attempted in the time given. For each one, the second column describes what the examiners are actually looking for - which is almost never a beautiful drawing.

Prompt	Time	What a strong answer contains
Draw the inside of a school bag, emptied, as if seen from directly above.	15 min	Correct plan view, honest proportion, every object labelled, one object drawn larger than the rest to show depth

Prompt	Time	What a strong answer contains
A chai stall owner needs a way to carry twelve glasses at once. Sketch your solution.	20 min	Three thumbnails, one chosen, a hand or a body shown for scale, and a note on why the other two were rejected
Draw a pair of scissors from three different angles on one page.	15 min	Consistent proportion across all three views, a clear light direction, and one detail enlarged
Design a dustbin for a railway platform that cannot be knocked over. Draw it in use.	20 min	The mechanism made visible, a person using it, and one labelled improvement over an ordinary bin
Draw a hand holding a glass of water, seen from the side.	12 min	Correct foreshortening of the fingers, the water line level, cast shadow where the glass meets the table
Sketch the sequence by which a folded newspaper becomes a paper boat, in four frames.	15 min	Four frames of equal size, each a genuine stage, with fold lines visible rather than erased
A child cannot reach the top shelf. Design something that helps, without a ladder.	20 min	A safe solution, the child and the shelf both drawn, and a note on what happens when the child is not using it
Draw an object from your kitchen that is badly designed, and one improvement to it.	18 min	The object drawn honestly, the flaw circled and labelled, the improvement shown as a second sketch rather than described

Notice what repeats across those eight: labels, scale figures, visible alternatives, and one circled improvement. None of that requires drawing talent. All of it requires deciding to include it before you start, because there is no time to add it afterwards.

37 NIFT GAT: fourteen practice questions

Fourteen questions in 15 minutes, which is close to the real pace of 72 seconds each. Minus 0.25 per wrong answer.

1 A shirt marked at Rs. 1,200 is sold at a 25 per cent discount. What is the selling price? (a) Rs. 850. (b) Rs. 900. (c) Rs. 950. (d) Rs. 1,000.

2 Two numbers are in the ratio 3:5 and their sum is 64. What is the smaller number? (a) 24. (b) 28. (c) 32. (d) 40.

3 A can finish a job in 10 days and B in 15. Working together, how long do they take? (a) 5 days. (b) 6 days. (c) 7.5 days. (d) 12.5 days.

4 A train covers 240 km in 3 hours. What is its speed in metres per second? (a) 18.5. (b) 20.0. (c) 22.2. (d) 24.0.

5 Choose the word closest in meaning to FRAGILE. (a) Flexible. (b) Delicate. (c) Rigid. (d) Hollow.

6 Choose the word opposite in meaning to ABUNDANT. (a) Plentiful. (b) Scarce. (c) Heavy. (d) Ample.

7 One word for a person who does not eat meat: (a) vegan. (b) vegetarian. (c) carnivore. (d) gourmet.

8 The idiom 'to let the cat out of the bag' means: (a) to lose something valuable. (b) to reveal a secret. (c) to escape danger. (d) to start a quarrel.

9 What comes next: 3, 9, 27, 81, ? (a) 162. (b) 216. (c) 243. (d) 324.

10 All pens are tools. Some tools are red. Which conclusion follows necessarily? (a) All pens are red. (b) Some pens are red. (c) No pen is red. (d) None of these follows necessarily.

11 If MONDAY is written as NPOEBZ, how is FRIDAY written? (a) GSJEBZ. (b) EQHCZX. (c) GSJDBZ. (d) GSKFBZ.

12 Which of these fibres is obtained from a plant stem? (a) Cotton. (b) Jute. (c) Silk. (d) Wool.

13 In the red-yellow-blue pigment system taught in art, which of these is a primary colour? (a) Green. (b) Orange. (c) Violet. (d) Yellow.

14 The weight of a fabric per unit area is measured in: (a) gsm. (b) denier. (c) count. (d) gauge.

Answers, in order: b, a, b, c, b, b, b, b, c, d, a, b, d, a. The two worth pausing on are question 10 - 'some tools are red' tells you nothing about whether any pen is among them, so no conclusion follows - and question 14, where denier measures fibre fineness and count measures yarn thickness, not fabric weight.

38 NID: eight studio and sensitivity prompts

These are the kind of situations the Mains rewards. Attempt each as a model where the prompt allows it, and as a spoken explanation where it does not. Give yourself 40 minutes for a model and two minutes to explain it.

1 Build a shelter for a small bird using only the paper and thread in front of you. Explain who it protects the bird from.

2 Make something that holds three different objects of different weights, using one material only.

3 Using a single sheet of paper, make the tallest structure you can that supports a full water bottle. Explain what you would change with a second sheet.

4 Model a bus stop for a village with no electricity. Justify one decision you made about the rain.

5 Make a container for something you cannot see, and describe what it is for without naming the object.

6 Using foil and thread, express the idea of 'waiting' as a three-dimensional object. Explain what a viewer would feel before they understood it.

7 Build a chair for a person who cannot bend their knees. Show where the difficulty was.

8 You are given a square of clay. Make something useful, then make it useless with one change. Explain the change.

The pattern in the scoring is not craftsmanship. It is whether the object you made answers the question that was asked, and whether you can say why in one clear sentence. Practise the sentence as much as the model - the In-Person Sensitivity Test is where a good model with no explanation loses to a plain model with a clear one.

39 NIFT's seven specialisations and twenty campuses

NIFT's B.Des is not one programme. It is seven, and they are not interchangeable. The 2027 seat matrix, including state domicile seats, is published and worth reading before you name a preference.

Programme	Regular	State domicile	Total 2027
B.Des Fashion Design (FD)	712	89	801
B.Des Fashion Communication (FC)	644	75	719
B.Des Textile Design (TD)	606	75	681
B.Des Accessory Design (AD)	576	61	637

Programme	Regular	State domicile	Total 2027
B.Des Knitwear Design (KD)	330	21	351
B.Des Leather Design (LD)	152	0	152
B.Des Fashion Interiors (FI)	68	14	82
B.Des total	3,088	335	3,423
B.F.Tech Apparel Production	542	49	591
All programmes, all campuses	4,596	480	5,076

Fashion Design is the biggest door by a wide margin - 801 seats against 82 in Fashion Interiors. If your only goal is a NIFT seat, that arithmetic matters. If your goal is a career, read the specialisation before you read the number: Fashion Interiors and Leather Design are small because few institutes teach them well, and small cohorts are not the same as weak ones.

The twenty campuses in the 2027 matrix are Bengaluru, Bhopal, Bhubaneswar, Chennai, Daman, Gandhinagar, Hyderabad, Jodhpur, Kangra, Kannur, Kolkata, Mumbai, Nava Raipur, New Delhi, Panchkula, Patna, Raebareli, Shillong, Srinagar and Varanasi. Bengaluru, Mumbai, New Delhi, Chennai, Kolkata, Gandhinagar, Hyderabad and Raebareli are the larger campuses; the remainder are smaller and newer.

NRI and foreign national seats are supernumerary and priced very differently. The 2027 matrix gives five supernumerary seats per programme at the eight larger campuses and three per programme at the other twelve. Fees follow the same split: NIFT's 2026-27 circular shows NRI tuition around Rs. 10 lakh a year at the larger campuses and around Rs. 7 lakh at the newer ones, against roughly Rs. 1.5 to 1.74 lakh per semester for non-NRI students.

40 Five myths that cost candidates a year

Each of these is stated confidently by someone, usually in a comment thread, and each is wrong in a way that has a documented consequence.

Myth one: you have to be good at drawing to get in. Partly true and mostly misleading. UCEED's own Part B qualifying cut-off is 15 out of 100 for the open category - you do not need to draw well, you need to not draw badly. What NIFT's CAT rewards is published: observation, concept development, composition, colour, illustration. Three of those five are decisions, not hand skills. The honest version is that drawing is the highest-leverage trainable skill in this book, which is not the same as saying talent is required.

Myth two: UCEED is the only route worth taking. UCEED has 245 seats nationally, of which IIT Bombay has 37 and IIT Indore 16. NIFT has 3,423 B.Des seats. NID has nine per discipline. Candidates who prepare for one exam and ignore the others are optimising a lottery ticket and ignoring the queue.

Myth three: a gap year keeps UCEED open. It does not. UCEED allows a maximum of two attempts, in consecutive years, and requires a first Class XII appearance in 2026 or 2027. A candidate who first sat Class XII in 2025 is ineligible for UCEED 2027 entirely, with one narrow board-result exception.

Myth four: you need coaching. NID states on its own registration page that it does not encourage coaching for its admission test and has not authorised anyone to conduct such classes. The syllabi for all four exams are published, the marking schemes are published, and the marks go to observation and craft. Coaching can help with structure and with speed on the GAT; it cannot supply the thing being tested.

Myth five: clearing the exam means you have a seat. It does not, in any of the four. UCEED requires a separate B.Des application in March 2027 and then five rounds of allotment. NID requires a separate

admission application after the Mains result - skip it and you become ineligible for seat allotment at every NID. NIFT requires the Situation Test, worth 20 per cent, before any merit list exists. CEED's own site says plainly that qualifying does not guarantee admission anywhere.

PART NINE

The toolkit

Print these pages or keep them open while you register. They are the parts you will actually use under time pressure.

41 The master checklist

Registration, for each of the three undergraduate exams.

- A working email address and mobile number you will still have in July 2027.
- Class XII marksheet or a school-issued certificate of appearance, depending on which form asks for what.
- A photograph within the specified size range: 10 to 200 KB as JPG for NIFT, and per the UCEED portal's specification for UCEED.
- A signature scan, 10 to 50 KB as JPG for NIFT.
- Category certificate if applicable, issued on or after 1 April 2026 for UCEED's exam stage.
- UDID or disability certificate as PDF, 50 to 300 KB, for NIFT.
- A debit card, credit card, UPI or net banking account in working order.
- A scanned copy of your passport, for NID's overseas category only.

Exam day, for all three.

- Printed admit card and a photo ID accepted by the conducting body.
- For paper-based components - UCEED Part B, NIFT CAT, NID Prelims - check the permitted stationery list on the admit card and carry nothing else.
- Report well before the gate closes. NIFT candidates are told to report at 9:00 am and are not admitted after 9:30 am.
- No identifying marks anywhere on a drawing, model or answer booklet. This is a disqualification, not a deduction.
- For UCEED: Part B booklets are distributed 30 minutes before the exam starts, so you have time to check the booklet and fill in your roll number.

42 Exam-day scripts

UCEED. Three hours, 300 marks, two parts. Budget 105 minutes for Part A and 75 for Part B, with the last 15 of Part B reserved for annotation. Within Part A, do NAT first - fourteen questions, no negative marking, so nothing is left blank. Then MCQ, because it rewards elimination. Then MSQ last, because it demands the most certainty and deserves a calm head. Hand over Part A before you open Part B; the parts are timed separately.

NIFT. GAT first, 100 questions in 120 minutes: sweep for the questions you can do in under a minute, then return. The CAT is 180 minutes for three questions - 55 minutes each with 15 minutes of checking at the

end. Spend the first five minutes of each question on thumbnails, not on the final drawing.

NID Prelims. Paper and pencil, English only. Read the whole paper before drawing anything; the questions are not equal in effort, and the ones worth the most marks are rarely the ones that look easiest. Carry a light pencil for construction lines and a dark one for the final.

43 The money worksheet

Line	UCEED	NIFT	NID
Application fee	Rs. 4,000	Rs. 2,000 or Rs. 3,000	Rs. 3,000
Late fee, avoidable	Rs. 500	Rs. 5,000	Not available
Travel and stay for exam	Your city	Your city	Your city
Seat acceptance	Rs. 65,000	Per campus schedule	Per NID schedule
Refundable portion	Rs. 60,000 if withdrawn by 7 Jul 2027	Varies	Varies
Four-year course fee, indicative	Per institute	About Rs. 14.09 lakh	Per campus

The one number to hold on to: NIFT's 2026-27 fee circular puts tuition at Rs. 1,50,000 per semester for semesters 1 and 2, Rs. 1,58,000 for semesters 3 and 4, Rs. 1,66,000 for semesters 5 and 6 and Rs. 1,74,000 for semesters 7 and 8, plus annual library, mediclaim, student development and exam charges, a one-time registration fee of Rs. 9,300, a refundable security deposit of Rs. 12,600 and a one-time alumni membership fee. Across eight semesters that lands close to Rs. 14.09 lakh before hostel and living costs. The 2027-28 circular will be published closer to admission and should be checked on nift.ac.in before you plan finances.

44 Sources and verification log

Every date, fee, weightage, seat number and rule in this book was taken from a primary source and checked on 31 October 2026. Where a source is a PDF published by the conducting body, the version is noted. Nothing here is drawn from coaching material, aggregator sites or secondary summaries.

Source	What it verified	Version checked
uceed.iitb.ac.in, UCEED 2027 Information Brochure	Exam pattern, marking, Part B cut-offs, eligibility, fees, seat matrix, seat allotment rounds, refund rules, result-sharing institutes	Version 1.0, released 1 October 2026
uceed.iitb.ac.in, Important Dates and Question Paper pages	Registration window, exam date, answer key dates, question paper structure	Checked 31 October 2026
ceed.iitb.ac.in, CEED 2027 site	Exam date, part structure, 0.25 and 0.75 weighting, eligibility, participating institutes, exam cities	Checked 31 October 2026
nift.ac.in, NIFTEE 2027 Information Bulletin (NTA)	Application dates, fees, GAT and CAT structure, marking, weightage, eligibility, age limits, situation test parameters, programme list	Published 16 October 2026
nift.ac.in, NIFT Admissions Guidelines 2027	Seat availability by campus and programme, NLEA tentative seats, NRI supernumerary seats, artisan skill test marks	Published 16 October 2026
nift.ac.in, Fee Circular 2026-27	Semester tuition and annual charges, one-time payments, NRI fee levels	Dated 13 May 2026

Source	What it verified	Version checked
admissions.nid.edu, NID Admissions Handbook 2027-28	Application window, DAT Prelims date, fees, age limits, seat intake, shortlisting ratio, Mains structure, test cities, NLEA and admission rules	2027-28 edition

Two caveats, stated plainly. First, conducting bodies revise dates and correct errors; the UCEED brochure itself says changes are notified as addendums on the official website only, and NIFT labels parts of its calendar tentative. Check the official portal before you act on any date in this book. Second, NIFT's internal marking for the Creative Ability Test is not published, so the score comparison in Chapter 16 uses scores out of 100 to show how the published weightage behaves - it is not a claim about how the CAT is marked.

45 Glossary

Term	What it means
AIR	All India Rank. In UCEED, rank is on Part A plus Part B combined, and only for candidates who clear the Part B cut-off.
CAT	In NIFT, the Creative Ability Test - three drawing questions, 50 per cent of the B.Des merit. Not to be confused with the CAT management entrance exam.
CEED	Common Entrance Examination for Design, the postgraduate route to M.Des and PhD.
CRL	Common Rank List, the unreserved ranking used in UCEED.
DAT	Design Aptitude Test, NID's two-stage entrance exam.
FMGE-free route	Not applicable here - but note that design degrees carry no licensing exam, unlike medicine or law.
GAT	General Ability Test, NIFT's computer-based objective paper.
MeriPehchaan	The Government of India single sign-on used by NTA portals, including NIFT's.
MSQ	Multiple Select Question - one or more correct options, with partial credit and a penalty for any wrong selection.
NAT	Numerical Answer Type - you type a number, with no options and no negative marking.
NLEA	NIFT Lateral Entry Admission, the diploma-holder route into the third semester.
PwBD	Person with Benchmark Disability, at least 40 per cent, as defined in the RPwD Act 2016.
Supernumerary	Seats added outside the main matrix, used for foreign nationals and overseas candidates.
UCEED	Undergraduate Common Entrance Examination for Design, conducted by IIT Bombay.

PART TEN

Beyond the exam

Three chapters that do not belong to any single exam, and that most guides leave out because they are harder to write than a date table.

46 What the work is actually like

A design degree is four years and a career is thirty. It is worth knowing what the second one looks like before you spend the first. What follows describes roles, not salaries - pay in design varies too widely by city, sector and portfolio to state a number honestly, and anyone quoting you a figure is selling something.

Fashion Design is the largest NIFT programme and the one with the clearest public image, which is also the most misleading. The visible job is the runway; the actual jobs are in product development for retail brands, in sampling and fit, in sourcing offices, and in the growing Indian market for ethnic and occasion wear where pattern-making and fabric behaviour matter more than sketching. The people who thrive tend to be the ones who enjoy the unglamorous middle of the process - specification sheets, fit sessions, vendor conversations.

Textile Design is the most technical of the seven and the least dependent on trends. Weaves, knits, prints, dyeing, surface development. The employers are mills, export houses, home-textile brands and the craft sector. It is a good choice for someone who likes material more than silhouette, and it travels well internationally because the skills are portable.

Knitwear Design and Leather Design are the two smallest programmes in the 2027 matrix, at 351 and 152 seats. Small does not mean weak. Both are specialist supply chains with few trained people, and both are concentrated in specific Indian clusters - Tiruppur and Ludhiana for knitwear, Kanpur, Chennai and Kolkata for leather. A specialist degree in a cluster industry can be a faster route to responsibility than a general one.

Fashion Communication covers the part of the industry that talks to the customer: styling, photography direction, editorial, brand communication, visual merchandising, content. It has 719 seats, second only to Fashion Design, and it is the natural home for someone who writes or photographs as well as draws. It is also the programme most exposed to the shift of fashion media onto short-form video.

Fashion Interiors, at 82 seats, sits between retail design and spatial design - store environments, displays, fixtures, the physical experience of a brand. It is the smallest B.Des programme and the one most often confused with interior design generally. It is not that; it is retail-focused.

B.F.Tech Apparel Production is the odd one out and worth taking seriously. It is engineering-adjacent: production planning, quality systems, industrial engineering, supply chain. The roles are plant and sourcing-side, they hire steadily, and they pay on a different curve from the design programmes. If you are a Maths student who wants the industry rather than the studio, this is the honest door.

On the IIT and NID side the map is different. Product and industrial design leads to consumer goods, appliances, mobility, medical devices and furniture. Interaction and UX design is the largest employer of design graduates in India today, and it is not confined to technology companies. Communication and graphic design leads to brand and identity work, publishing, packaging and advertising. Animation and film design leads to studios, broadcast and increasingly to AI-assisted production. Exhibition, retail-experience and furniture design lead to spatial practices, museums, events and retail rollouts.

One honest caveat. None of these degrees comes with a placement guarantee, and the first job is usually more junior than the brochure implies. What the degree buys is a portfolio, a peer network and four years of supervised practice - which is a real asset, and a different thing from a promise.

47 The parent's page

If you are the parent reading this rather than the candidate, here is the whole thing in one page.

What is being decided. Your child is applying to a design degree, which in India means sitting up to three entrance exams in December and January and then a counselling process that runs to July. The exams are not interchangeable and the deadlines are not simultaneous: the first two close in October and November, the last in November, and the earliest exam is on 20 December 2026.

What it costs. The application fees are small - Rs. 2,000 to Rs. 4,000 each. The degree is not. NIFT's published fee circular puts tuition at Rs. 1,50,000 per semester in the first year, rising to Rs. 1,74,000 by the fourth, with annual library, insurance, student-development and exam charges on top, a one-time

registration fee and a refundable security deposit. Across eight semesters that is close to Rs. 14.09 lakh before hostel and living costs. IIT and NID fee structures are published separately by each institute closer to admission, and are generally lower than NIFT's.

What the risk is. UCEED offers 245 seats nationally. NIFT offers 3,423 B.Des seats. NID offers nine seats per discipline at each campus. A sensible plan registers for all three and treats them as one preparation, because the skills overlap. A plan that registers for one is a plan with a low probability attached to it.

What is worth doing in the next six weeks. Make sure the registrations are done and paid - the deadlines in Part Two are hard, and there is no offline route or agent route that is legitimate. Check that the documents are in order, particularly category certificates, which must be issued after 1 April 2026 for UCEED's exam stage. And buy the paper and pencils; the preparation for these exams is largely a drawing habit, and it is cheap.

What is not worth doing. Paying an agent to secure admission. All four conducting bodies collect only through their own portals, all four publish their rules, and no one can guarantee a seat outside the prescribed process. NID states on its own site that it has not authorised anyone to conduct coaching for its test. Money spent on guaranteed admission is money spent on a promise nobody can keep.

What to say to a child who does not get in. There are real second routes - NIFT's lateral entry for diploma holders, its Artisan category, and 47 institutes that accepted UCEED scores in the 2026 cycle - and there is a genuine second attempt at UCEED, provided it is the next consecutive year. A year spent building a portfolio is not a wasted year in this field; it is often the year that makes the difference.

48 If you are reading this after the deadlines

This book is dated, and pretending otherwise would be dishonest. If the windows in Part Two have closed, here is what is still open.

NIFT's Artisan category takes applications until 31 January 2027, and its PhD and international categories until the same date. NIFT's NLEA route has a tentative 401 seats for diploma holders entering the third semester. If either applies to you, the application windows are far longer than the regular ones.

The result-sharing route stays open after every deadline, because it depends on a score you already hold or can earn next year. In the 2026 cycle, 47 institutes accepted UCEED scores, including BITS Design School, FLAME University, Mahindra University, CEPT University, FDDI, Srishti Manipal, Shiv Nadar, Anant National University, MIT ID and Delhi Technological University. Those institutes run their own admission processes on their own calendars, and several do not require UCEED at all - they run their own tests or accept a portfolio. If you missed the national deadlines, this is the list to work through, one institute at a time, this week.

If you are planning for the next cycle, the pattern is stable enough to plan against. UCEED and CEED registration opens in the first week of October and closes at the end of October, with a late window into early November. NIFT registration opens in mid-October and closes in mid-November. NID opens in early September and closes at the end of November. NID's prelims are in the third week of December; NIFT's exam is in the second week of January; UCEED and CEED share a date in the third week of January. Build the calendar backwards from those dates and you will never be surprised by one.

And if you are reading this in the middle of the cycle with three weeks left and no preparation: start at Chapter 34. Attempt the twenty questions, mark them, read the explanations, then do the drawing prompts in Chapter 36. Three weeks of honest daily practice is enough to clear a Part B cut-off of 15 out of 100, and that alone changes what the rest of your application can do.

This playbook is a study and application guide. It does not replace the official information brochures of IIT Bombay, NTA, NIFT or NID, and it confers no admission rights. Where this book and an official portal disagree, the official portal is correct.

Prepared 31 October 2026 for the 2027-28 admission cycle. Digital edition, digitalkartai.shop.